



Central America

VOLCANOES, EARTHQUAKES, and hurricanes threaten the livelihoods of people in the seven countries of Central America. People here have also struggled with poverty and civil war. In more recent years, however, peace and economic recovery have offered hope, and education is now free in all countries. Remains of the ancient Mayan civilization that flourished until the 16th century, when the Spanish invaded, can be seen throughout the region. Large numbers of the native population died after the invasion, mostly from disease. Today, Spanish is the main language of the region.

Lake Nicaragua is the only freshwater lake in the world that contains sharks.

FAUNA AND FLORA
Ecotourism, which encourages visitors but aims to protect and preserve the environment, is increasingly important in the region. In Belize, tourists can dive in the clear, warm waters off the world's second largest barrier reef, and there are wildlife treks to many forest areas. Animals include jaguars, howler monkeys, and butterflies.

TEMPLE PYRAMIDS
Between 250–900 CE, the Maya designed ceremonial centers filled with temples, courts, and plazas. Without metal, they shaped tools from the solid lava of volcanoes to carve the limestone buildings. One of the largest sites is at Tikal (left), in Guatemala, where temple remains lie in a huge area of tropical rainforest.

DECORATED CHURCHES
The Spanish colonizers of the 1500s, and the missionaries who came with them, converted the native population and established Roman Catholicism throughout Central America. They also built many fabulously decorated churches. The one shown here, El Merced, is built in a low, squat style to resist the ever-present threat of earthquakes. The majority of people still follow the Roman Catholic faith.

VOLCANIC REGION
Central America is an unstable area because it lies along the meeting point of two of Earth's tectonic plates. There are at least 14 active volcanoes here, including Volcán de Pacaya (right). Although this makes it a dangerous place to live, the volcanic soil is very fertile and good for crops.

Pyramid with nine sloping terraces

Steps leading up to the temple at the top

